mastercard foundation

In partnership with TechnoServe Business Solutions to Poverty

BlueBiz Program

January - March 2025 | Issue 2

March 2025

BlueBiz Wave *Newsletter*

Welcome aboard the BlueBiz Wave, your go-to newsletter for the latest trends, opportunities, and success stories in the vibrant world of the Blue Economy. Whether you're a budding enthusiast, or a community advocate, this is your gateway to the exciting future of coastal innovation and sustainable business.

The Blue Economy represents a wave of opportunity for young persons, offering innovative ways to create sustainable livelihoods while preserving our precious marine ecosystems. From oyster farming to seaweed cultivation,and from eco-tourism ventures to cutting-edge mariculture projects, coastal youth are redefining entrepreneurship and unlocking potential like never before.

A BlueBiz Program participant showcasing her honey products during the Mastercard Foundation international women's day celebrations.

What's in This Issue?
Inspiring Stories: Dive into real-life success stories of young entrepreneurs who've made waves in the Blue Economy.

Exclusive Invites:
Be the first to know about workshops, networking events, and funding opportunities tailored for coastal youth.

Tips & Resources: Access expert advice and tools to kickstart or grow your Blue Economy venture. Stay ahead of the curve. This is more than a newsletter, it's a movement.

Don't just watch the tide rise; ride the wave of change! Stay informed, get inspired, and be a part of the Blue Economy revolution shaping the future of our coastal communities.

Ready to Dive In? Share and join us as we celebrate the creativity and resilience of youth entrepreneurship in the Blue Economy. Together, we can build sustainable solutions for a thriving marine future.

Meet the New Faces of BlueBiz

This quarter, we were delighted to welcome new team members to the BlueBiz family! As we continue to grow and scale our impact in the Blue Economy, these talented individuals bring fresh perspectives, expertise, and passion to our mission.

Each new team member plays a vital role in strengthening our support for young entrepreneurs. Their skills and dedication will help drive innovation, enhance partnerships, and create more opportunities for youth and women in the coastal economy.

Join us in extending a warm welcome to our newest colleagues as they embark on this journey with us. Together, we are building a stronger, more inclusive Blue Economy!

Joanne Muchangi
Market Systems Development & Partnerships Manager

James Mwanjau
Sub Award & Enterprise Development Manager

Stacy Tumaini
Program Intern

Nancy Nyale
Program Intern

Building Stronger Partnerships for Market Access

At BlueBiz, strategic partnerships play a crucial role in expanding opportunities for young entrepreneurs in the Blue Economy. Through collaborative efforts with government agencies, private sector players, and local organizations, we continue to strengthen market linkages, providing sustainable pathways for business growth.

During a recent visit to Lamu County, our engagement with partners in fish processing, cold storage, and value addition reinforced the need for enhanced collaboration to improve market access. The Rasini Cold Storage Facility, a key stakeholder in the sector, is actively working with BlueBiz participants to ensure better fish preservation and improved supply chains. Additionally, our partnerships with local organizations, financial institutions, and investors are paving the way for youth-led enterprises to access funding, mentorship, and scaling opportunities. By fostering these collaborations, we are not only unlocking markets but also creating sustainable livelihoods in coastal communities.

Fish Preservation

As we move forward, strengthening partnerships remains a priority ensuring that young entrepreneurs have the resources, networks, and support needed to thrive in the Blue Economy.

Mastercard Foundation Kenya Partner Communications Community of Practice (CoP) Q1 Forum 2025

Emmaculate Kivindyo, Communications Advisor BlueBiz Program, (third from left) in a panel discussion at the Mastercard Foundation CoP Q1 Forum. 2025

Building on the momentum from the December 2024 forum, the Kenya Partner Communications Community of Practice (CoP) Q1 session provided a platform to track progress and strengthen collaborative efforts among partners. During this session, partners reported on key developments since the formation of cluster groups and reaffirmed their commitment to implementing collaborative activities and young women-centric strategies for 2025.

International Women's Day, MSMEs Connect, and GROOTS Kenya @30. With a shared vision for impact, BlueBiz remains committed to fostering an inclusive, financially empowered, and thriving MSME ecosystem, ensuring that young entrepreneurs especially women have the resources and support they need to flourish in the Blue Economy. As a panelist in the MSME Finance Cluster discussion.

Our Communications Advisor, Emmaculate Kivindyo, shared key insights on:

- Holistic MSME Growth: Equipping young entrepreneurs with financial literacy, technical skills, and funding access to ensure long-term success.
- Inclusive Financial Empowerment: Addressing gender and cultural barriers to ensure women entrepreneurs retain financial independence and actively participate in decision-making.
- Impact-Driven Storytelling: Strengthening joint communication efforts, amplifying success stories, and participating in high-profile engagements like International Women's Day, MSMEs Connect, and GROOTS Kenya @30.

With a shared vision for impact, BlueBiz remains committed to fostering an inclusive, financially empowered, and thriving MSME ecosystem, ensuring that young entrepreneurs especially women have the resources and support they need to flourish in the Blue Economy.

Emmaculate Kivindyo, Communications Advisor, BlueBiz Program (right), at the Mastercard Foundation CoP Q1 Forum 2025.

Empowering Persons with Disabilities in the Blue Economy

As part of its commitment to inclusivity, a recent field assessment conducted in Mombasa, Lamu, and Tana River Counties evaluated the participation of Persons with Disabilities (PWDs) in the Blue Economy. The initiative aims to mobilize 750 PWDs by 2027, with 137 individuals already engaged to date. Key challenges identified include limited accessibility to training and workspaces, financial constraints, social stigma, and communication barriers. To address these, the program has introduced transport stipends, caregiver support, inclusive training methods (Braille, sign language, digital tools), and business development support.

Partnerships with organizations like Big Ship CBO, Action Life, and Kipini Integrated Community Enterprise (KICE) have enabled PWDs to engage in mangrove conservation, aquaculture, seaweed farming, and crafts enterprises, promoting sustainable income and social inclusion.

The BlueBiz Program team, Light for the World team, and BlueBiz local implementing partners during the Disability Inclusion Training.

Moving forward, BlueBiz is scaling up awareness campaigns, enhancing employment linkages with the private sector, and strengthening monitoring frameworks to ensure greater PWD participation in the Blue Economy. By breaking barriers and fostering inclusivity, BlueBiz is paving the way for a more accessible and economically empowering future for all.

Mastercard Foundation International Women's Day Celebrations

ABOVE: A BlueBiz Program participant showcases her products during the Mastercard Foundation International Women's Day celebration.

LEFT: BlueBiz Program participants at the Mastercard Foundation International Women's Day celebration.

Bluebiz made waves at the MasterCard Foundation international women's day celebrations held in Nairobi on 11th March. With an electrifying campaign “Accelerate Action", it was more than a celebration; it was a bold call to action to uplift, empower, and support women in the Blue Economy.

During the vibrant celebration, three of our inspiring participants displayed their innovative products and made impressive sales. Their success not only highlights the creativity and entrepreneurial spirit of young women in the Blue Economy but also reinforces the tangible impact of inclusive initiatives.

These inspiring achievements serve as a powerful reminder of the immense potential that lies in empowering women-led ventures. Their stories are sparking conversations, fueling further innovation, and setting new benchmarks for success in our coastal communities.

Kipini Integrated Community Enterprise CBO and Pamoja Pwani Network Joint International Women's Day Event

Hon. Danson Mungatana, Tana River County Senator (wearing a plain white shirt), commemorating the joint International Women's Day event.

Our local implementing partners, Kipini Integrated Community Enterprise (KICE CBO) and Pamoja Pwani Network (PPN), played a key role in organizing a joint International Women's Day event, showcasing the impact of the BlueBiz Program in Tana River County. They had the honor of hosting Tana River County Senator, Hon. Danson Mungatana, who joined them to commemorate this special occasion.

He was thrilled to engage with young entrepreneurs from the BlueBiz Program, representing Kipini Integrated Community Enterprise and Pamoja Pwani Network , as they showcased their innovative products from the fisheries value chain. This moment provided an opportunity to highlight BlueBiz's commitment to empowering young women and men in Tana River County's Blue Economy through skills development, financial access, and market linkages.

At the Exhibition Point: Participants proudly displayed a diverse range of products, including live fish, dried fish, prawns, lobsters, red snapper, and exciting value-added products like fish samosas and cutlets.

This joint International Women's Day event was not just a celebration, it was a powerful platform to showcase the entrepreneurial spirit of young people in the Blue Economy and reinforce our commitment to fostering inclusive economic growth.

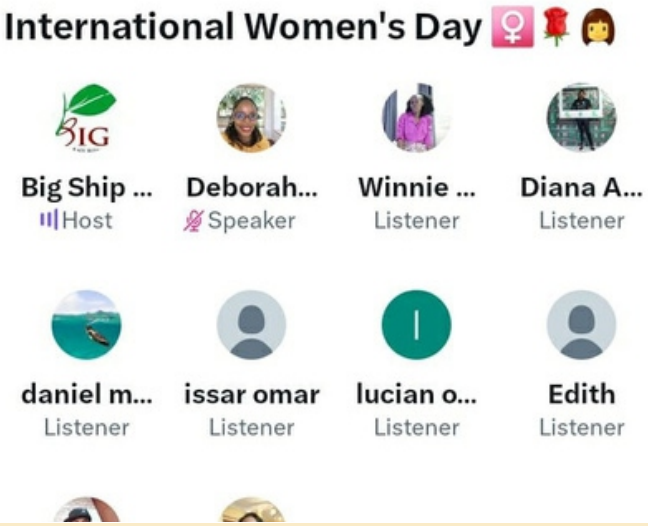
BlueBiz Program participants showcase their products during the joint International Women's Day event.

Big Ship Hosts Twitter Space for International Women's Day

As part of the International Women's Day celebrations, Big Ship hosted an engaging Twitter Space conversation, bringing together voices from the Blue Economy to discuss this year's theme: "Invest in Women: Accelerate Progress."

The session featured industry leaders, young entrepreneurs, and advocates, diving into key issues such as gender equity in coastal enterprises, financial inclusion for women, and breaking barriers in traditionally male-dominated sectors.

With insightful discussions and inspiring success stories, the conversation underscored the critical role women play in shaping a sustainable Blue Economy.



The Twitter Space, hosted by Big Ship as part of the International Women's Day celebrations.

Mobilization of Cohort III is in progress

Mobilization of participants for Cohort III of the BlueBiz Program.

The registration of young entrepreneurs for Cohort III of the BlueBiz Program is making great strides! With outreach efforts intensifying across Mombasa, Kilifi, Kwale, Lamu, and Tana River counties, we are seeing an enthusiastic response from aspiring business owners' eager to tap into opportunities in the Blue Economy.

Through strategic partnerships, community engagements, and awareness drives, the BlueBiz team, alongside our local implementing partners, is ensuring that more young people gain access to business development support, financial linkages, and mentorship opportunities.

As we continue this journey, we are excited to welcome a new wave of young passionate entrepreneurs who will drive innovation and sustainability in the blue economy sector.

Empowering Women in the Blue Economy

BlueBiz Program participants in the coconut value chain featured in the International Women's Day video.

As part of our commitment to fostering an inclusive Blue Economy, BlueBiz recently conducted a Gender and Youth Inclusion Training, equipping 37 participants (26 women, 11 men) from Mombasa, Kilifi, Kwale, Lamu, and Tana River with the skills to integrate gender and youth perspectives into their work.

The training led to the development of Young Women-Centric Design (YWCD) approaches, county-specific action plans, and a GBV referral pathway linking 30 partner organizations. Discussions revealed key challenges faced by BlueBiz participants, including physical, sexual, economic, and psychological abuse, with cases of harassment, financial control, and intimidation. To address these issues, the training strengthened GBV response mechanisms by mapping support services and fostering community partnerships.

Moving forward, we remain committed to implementing action plans, enhancing GBV interventions, and driving sustainable, inclusive growth in the Blue Economy.

BlueBiz Program participants in the aquaculture value chain featured in the International Women's Day video.

Due Diligence: Ensuring Transparency & Accountability

The BlueBiz Program team with the Kipini Integrated Community Enterprise team during a due diligence visit in Tana River County

At BlueBiz, due diligence isn't just a process, it's a promise. This month, we reinforced our commitment to ethical business practices through targeted due diligence efforts for our partners and stakeholders.

What We're Doing:

- Implementing stronger risk assessments for partnerships.
- Promoting transparency in financial & business decisions.
- Ensuring that every BlueBiz initiative is aligned with accountability best practices.

These measures guarantee that our youth entrepreneurs receive the best possible support in a responsible, transparent, and sustainable manner.

Why It Matters:

Due diligence is essential in fostering an environment where transparency and accountability are the norm. This ensures that our ventures are not only innovative but also resilient and ethically grounded. As we continue to expand our reach, our focus on due diligence enables us to set new benchmarks for excellence and integrity.

The BlueBiz Program team, together with the Dream Achievers Youth Organisation team, during a due diligence visit in Mombasa County

Impact Stories: Amplifying Voices, Inspiring Change

At BlueBiz, every success story fuels our passion for a sustainable Blue Economy. This month, we're proud to spotlight the remarkable journeys of young coastal entrepreneurs who are transforming their communities.

Their stories of resilience, innovation, and determination are not just narratives, they are powerful proof that change is happening, one idea at a time.

Each impact story is a testament to the relentless spirit of our participants, inspiring others to dream big and act boldly. Join us as we celebrate these trailblazers, whose achievements continue to redefine the future of coastal entrepreneurship.

Sada Khamisi, a BlueBiz Program participant from Lamu County, sharing her business growth experience.

Launch of the BlueBiz Digital Toolbox!

We're excited to announce the official launch of the BlueBiz Digital Toolbox a groundbreaking resource designed to empower young entrepreneurs in the Blue Economy!
This one-stop digital hub provides essential tools, insights, and strategies to help businesses start, grow, and scale. Whether you're a budding entrepreneur or looking to expand your venture, the Digital Toolbox is here to equip you with the knowledge and resources needed to succeed.

Packed with practical tools, templates, and guides, this online resource hub offers invaluable support in key areas such as business development, financial management, and market access.

The Digital Toolbox ensures that entrepreneurs have everything they need to navigate challenges, seize opportunities, and build thriving businesses in the Blue Economy.

At BlueBiz, we believe that access to the right information unlocks endless opportunities. This toolbox is a significant step toward ensuring that every entrepreneur has the support they need to succeed.

Don't get left behind! Explore the Bluebiz digital toolbox today and take your business to the next level.
The BlueBiz digital toolbox is now live! access it here
bluebizkenya.com

Launch of the BlueBiz Program Digital Toolbox.

TechnoServe Kenya's Country Director Engages with BlueBiz Participants in Lamu County

Kris Ansin, TechnoServe Country Director, engaging with BlueBiz Program participants in Lamu County.

We had the privilege of hosting Kris Ansin, TechnoServe Kenya's Country Director, for an inspiring visit to the BlueBiz Program. The visit was a dynamic exchange, featuring powerful success stories, insightful discussions, and firsthand interactions with young entrepreneurs driving innovation in the Blue Economy.

While in Lamu County, the Country Director engaged with BlueBiz participants involved in fish processing, fresh fish trading, and value addition enterprises. A key highlight was a visit to the Rasini Cold Storage Facility, where ongoing efforts to enhance fish preservation and expand market access were showcased.

Additionally, discussions with women-led businesses shed light on how value addition is creating sustainable livelihoods along the coastal region. This visit reaffirmed TechnoServe's commitment to empowering youth and women in coastal enterprises through mentorship, funding opportunities, and business development solutions. Exciting collaborations are on the horizon stay tuned for more updates!

Wangari Theuri, Senior Program Manager of the BlueBiz Program, and Kris Ansin, TechnoServe Country Director, during the Mawimbi seaweed farmers site visit.

A Publication of BluBiz Program.
Editor/Writer Emmaculate Kivindyo | Photography: Brian Wachira
For more information contact:ekivindyo@tns.org